

How's AI destroying water , land and air?

Posted by u/Yaveltal • 0 points • 13 comments

I understand the pushback against generative AI and AI art, as it can do stuff such as spread misinformation or steal from actual artists, so I understand those reason, but some people also claim it's destroying the water air and land? How exactly is it doing so?

Comments

u/_Dingaloo • 1 points • 2026-02-25 01:20 UTC

The "pro" AI way of looking at this without being a shill is basically this.

There have been many industries around datacenters that have exploded in the last decade. TONS of new datacenters already went up. Some issues arose from them, but nothing crazy.

Why was this ok? Because regulation did its job. Because when power demands rose, they were able to be met and were met with proportionate resources in a good timeframe. The idea should be that these datacenters enrich the areas that they are in; the taxes that come in from the bills that they pay alone should be enough to enrich the surrounding area. That is how proper taxation and regulation has improved the lives for not just the individual making industry, but for all those around them as well in the past.

Now? There are subsidies *for* AI. There is huge capital investment in it. There are less regulations and price adjustments for it. There are laws that *literally* prevent more laws from being made to regulate it.

AI is a good thing, in general. But because our government is so corrupt at this point in time (always has been, we just somehow continue to reach new heights) we are literally making surrounding areas *worse* by adding datacenters.

We have the water, we have the capability and resource to increase power output without destroying the prices, we have the ability to extract the resources to keep making chips and computer parts. These are not hard limitations that we have as a society. The reason we see these issues now is because we are putting the output of AI so far ahead of the redistribution of wealth via taxes and the control of damages through regulation, that the system isn't working. I mean, if you literally turn the system off, *obviously* it won't work

u/ExhaustedByStupidity • 1 points • 2026-02-24 22:45 UTC

AI requires huge datacenters filled with lots and lots of computers. Enough computers that most of the manufacturing capacity for memory and storage for the next few years is already reserved for AI companies.

These datacenters require a lot of land and electricity.

The computers generate a lot of heat. The most effective way to cool them is to pump water through to absorb the heat. A lot of that water ends up evaporating.

Manufacturing chips also requires a ton of clean water.

AI is being rolled out at a massive scale, so all the land, water, and electricity use adds up fast.

u/bangbangracer • 1 points • 2026-02-24 22:24 UTC

Water is the big one. They need lots of water for cooling purposes. The water cycle is slow and reservoirs don't replenish fast enough to keep up with general demand as is. We already are pulling more from reservoirs than the water cycle is replacing, and AI just increases how much we are pulling.

Then we need to look at power consumption and where it comes from. Unless you have a lot of green options nearby, electricity is generated by fuel burners boiling water to spin a generator. More electrical demand means more fuel burned, and more fuel burned means more emissions.

u/Royal_Annex • 2 points • 2026-02-24 22:21 UTC

AI takes huge data centers which use tons of water and electricity, create pollution, and of course are situated on land.

That's all normal stuff for a business that makes something useful. They don't though.

u/unic0de000 • 5 points • 2026-02-24 22:13 UTC

Water is mostly consumed for cooling purposes. High-performance computing servers make a lot of heat. So the operators take cool water from local natural sources, pour it through the datacenter cooling pipes, and it comes out as hot water and a lot of steam. And the steam escapes into the atmosphere instead of being returned to circulation locally, and the hot water may create its own problems for the local plant and animal life, depending on how it's handled from there.

Air, because the electricity to run all these computers is being generated *mostly* by burning coal, oil and gas. There are some renewable sources in the mix too, but when the demand for computer juice is so high, those sources stay saturated, and fossil power picks up the slack.

Land is probably the least-wasted resource by datacenters, because at least their physical footprint is still pretty small compared to other industries.

But then again, even when AI datacenters don't physically occupy huge amounts of land, they *can* make lots of nearby land a lot less suitable for human habitation. [Here's a recent video by music and tech youtuber Benn Jordan](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_bP80DEAbuo) about how some datacenters have been making people ill, by producing huge amounts of ultra-low-frequency sound pollution.

u/Yaveltal • 2 points • 2026-02-24 22:23 UTC

Oh, that actually makes sense. Thank you for your answer

u/AccountNumber478 • 4 points • 2026-02-24 22:11 UTC

Aside from data centers and the environmental impact, I'd suggest AIs misinforming people can lead to wasteful transactions and wasted resources to fulfill those transactions.

Case in point, an AI is asked about a very niche, specific replacement part for some widget, a car or bike or kitchen appliance or toilet, whatever. The human provides very specific data, reference codes, part numbers, even photos. Unfortunately, the AI flubs something, and emits a recommendation the user purchase a part that seems okay but isn't, and takes the AI's word for it. Product is shipped, whether domestically or internationally, arrives, and is found to be unsuitable. Then, product needs to be returned and goes back home, or gets tossed in a recycle bin or landfill.

On top of wasted fuel, there's wasted energy in the whole enterprise thanks to AI's mistaken identification, and the user's misplaced trust at face value.

u/_Dingaloo • 0 points • 2026-02-25 01:22 UTC

It's an ok point but I'd argue that was happening just as much before, if not more. I argue more because AI is fairly accurate today for the majority of use cases, and people were overall not very good at looking stuff up -- you'd be praised for learning something that you figured out by spending 5 minutes on a wikihow. That's just a skill most people did not care to have for whichever reason.

u/unic0de000 • 3 points • 2026-02-24 22:20 UTC

That's a great point. The extra work which people and organizations have to do in order to sanity-check the AI's outputs, and the catastrophes which can happen when they don't, are economically and environmentally wasteful in their own right.

u/MikeKrombopulos • 3 points • 2026-02-24 22:06 UTC

They're not destroying water and land, but they are taking up a lot of land and require water to cool the hardware, and there's only so much water that local water systems have the resources to clean.

u/Kindly_Row_2789 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 22:05 UTC

AI's pretty energy-intensive. All those data centers need tons of electricity, which often means more fossil fuels burned. That's where the environmental impact comes in. Not exactly a tree-hugger's dream.

u/SocYS4 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 22:04 UTC

data centers contaminate the nearby air with pollution

u/Fearlessleader85 • 1 points • 2026-02-24 22:38 UTC

That's not really true. Data centers don't pollute the air anymore than your personal computer does.

They do need a MASSIVE amount of electricity, but that's generally not produced nearby. They also need a lot of cooling and that's generally done with large water-cooled AC plants, because evaporative cooling is the most electrically efficient way to do this, but that cooling doesn't produce any more pollution than the AC system at all your local large public buildings or office buildings.

AI is energy intensive, which produces problems for the grid. It requires a lot of water to evaporate off to cool it, but that water isn't destroyed or lost to the world, it's just a local problem if

the center is in a place without much water, like the massive data centers in Prineville, Oregon. These are real problems. Don't make up bullshit ones.